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The Promotion of True Religious Unity

His Holiness, Pope Pius XI

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To Our Venerable Brethren, Patriarchs, Primates, Archbishops, Bishops and to all Ordinaries in Peace and Communion with the Apostolic See; Venerable Brethren, Greetings and Apostolic Benediction:

The will to strengthen and to diffuse for the common good of human society that brotherhood in which we are all closely united by the bonds of a common nature and origin has never perhaps so taken hold of men's minds as in our times. When nations do not fully enjoy the blessings of peace, and old and new discords break forth into mutiny and conflict; when, indeed, it is impossible to settle the numerous controversies that strike at the peace and prosperity of peoples without the harmonious action of those who govern states and rule and promote their interests, it is easily understood, and all the more so now that all accept the unity of mankind, how it is that, impelled by the desire for universal brotherhood, many should be anxious that the various nations stand ever more closely together.

Some are seeking to accomplish a thing not unlike this in matters that concern the ordinations of the New Law which Christ brought to us. Convinced that rarely, indeed, do men lack all sense of religion, they seem to draw from this reason to hope that without great difficulty it may come about that all peoples, no matter how different their religions, will stand fraternally together in the profession of a few doctrines which will serve as a kind of common foundation for the spiritual life. There-

fore they are accustomed to call congresses, reunions and meetings which are attended by many persons and they invite there indiscriminately to decide the question, infidels of all kinds and Christians alike and even those who have miserably apostatized from Christ or who intransigeantly and tenaciously deny the Divinity of His person and mission.

Catholics Cannot Approve

Certainly such undertakings as these cannot gain the approval of Catholics since they are founded upon the false teaching of those who say that since all religions equally unfold and signify, though not in the same way, that native, inborn feeling in us all through which we are borne toward God and humbly recognize His rule, therefore all religions are more or less good and praiseworthy. The followers of this theory are deceived and mistaken and since they repudiate the true religion by attacking it in its very essence, they are in fact moving step by step to naturalism and atheism. Hence it clearly follows that he who gives assent to such theories and undertakings separates hmiself wholly from Divinely revealed religion.

When the question of promoting unity among Christians is under consideration many are easily deceived by the semblance of good. Is it not right, it is said repeatedly, indeed, does it not conform with the duty of all who call upon Christ's name to cease mutual recriminations and in ties of mutual charity join together? For who would dare to say that he loves Christ when he will not strive to his utmost to attain what Christ prayed for to His Father when He asked that His disciples might "be one?"[1] And did not Christ wish His disciples to bear the sign and be distinguished by the characteristic of love towards one another: "By this shall all men know that you are My disciples, if you have love one for another?"[2] Would that all Christians were one, they add, in order that the evil of irreligion might be driven from us which now is spreading more widely every day and threatens to overturn the Gospel itself.

[1]John xvii, 21. [2]John xiii, 35.

Directed By Non-Catholics

These and like arguments are brought forward and amplified by those who call themselves Pan-Christians. They are no longer confined to small and scattered groups but, so to speak, they are growing by whole phalanxes and are uniting themselves in extensive organizations which although they themselves are of different faiths are directed for the most part by non-Catholics. The work itself is promoted with such zeal that it has already gained a great variety of followers and has even ensnared the minds of Catholics with the entrancing hope of attaining a union that would seem to meet the will of Holy Mother Church to whom nothing is more hallowed than the recall and the return of her wandering children to her bosom. Yet beneath the coaxing words there is concealed an error so great that it would result in destroying totally the foundations of the Catholic Faith.

In the consciousness of Our Apostolic office not to let the flock of the Lord be led astray by error, We invoke your zeal, Venerable Brethren, to ward off this evil; for We are convinced that by means of your writings and your words, the principles and reasons We shall expound will more quickly reach the people and they will come better to understand them so that they will know how to judge and how to conduct themselves in relation to the efforts made to coalesce in one body through some sort of a pact all who call themselves Christians.

Church Established By Christ

God, the Maker of the universe, created us that we might know and serve Him; it follows that our Maker has full right that we serve Him. For the governance of mankind God could have prescribed only the one law of nature which He wrote upon the mind of man at his creation and thenceforward He could have ruled the steps of this law under His customary providence. Instead He preferred to give us the Commandments to prepare us, and in the course of the centuries from the origin of mankind to the coming and teaching of Christ Jesus He

wished Himself to teach man the duties that rational beings owe their Creator.

"God, who, at sundry times and in divers manners, spoke in times past to the fathers by the prophets, last of all, in these days hath spoken to us by His Son."[3] From this it follows that the true religion cannot be other than that which is founded in the revealed word of God. This revelation, started at the beginning of time and continued in the Old Testament, Christ Jesus Himself perfected in the New. Now if God has spoken—and that He has indeed spoken is historically certain—there is no one who does not see that it is man's duty to believe God absolutely in His revelations and to obey Him without qualification in His Commandments; and precisely that we may rightly fulfil both duties for the glory of God and our own salvation, the Only Begotten Son of God founded His Church upon earth.

They who profess themselves Christians cannot, we think, but believe in Christ's establishment of one Church and one Church alone; but when one asks what that Church ought by the will of its Founder to be, then not all are in agreement. Indeed a great many deny, for example, that Christ's Church ought to be visible; at least in the sense that it should stand forth as one body of faithful united in one identical doctrine and under one head. On the contrary they understand by a visible church nothing but a society formed of various Christian communities even though these adhere to different doctrines and even to doctrines mutually contradictory.

Instead the Church which Christ Our Lord founded is a perfect society, external of its own nature and visible, which would pursue for all future time the task of saving mankind through the guidance of one head[4]; through being taught by a living voice[5]; and through the dispensation[6]; of the sacraments, those fountains of heavenly grace; wherefore, in His parables He likened His Church to a kingdom[7]; to a house[8]; to a sheepfold[9]; to a flock[10].

[3]Hebr. i, 1 sq.
[4]Matt. xvi, 18 seq.; Lk. xxii, 32; John xxi, 15-17.
[5]Mark xvi, 15.
[6]John iii, 5; vi, 48-59; xx, 22 seq.; cf. Matt. xviii, 18, etc.
[7]Matt. xi, 33. [8]Cf. Matt. xvi, 18. [9]John x, 16. [10]John xxi, 15-17.

Such a Church so marvelously constituted could not cease altogether and be extinguished when its Founder and the Apostles who first propagated it had died, because it had been commanded to lead to eternal salvation all men without distinction of time, or place: "Going, therefore, teach all nations."[11] Would the Church lack power or efficacy for the perpetual fulfilment of this work when Christ Himself is perpetually present with it, as He solemnly promised: "Behold I am with you all days even to the consummation of the world"?[12] Necessarily, therefore, the Church of Christ ought not only to stand today and always, but still more it ought to remain the same as it was in the Apostolic ages, unless we should wish to utter the absurdity that Christ Our Lord either had not been adequate to His purpose or had erred when He asserted that "the gates of hell shall not prevail against it."[13]

Opportunity to Remove Falsity

And here there is presented the opportunity of setting forth and removing a falsity upon which it seems this whole question hinges and from which is drawn the origin of the multiple effort of these non-Catholics who are striving, as we have said, for the confederation of the Christian churches.

The authors of this plan are in the habit of quoting the words of Christ: "That they all may be one. . . . There shall be one fold and one shepherd,"[14] yet in the sense that these words express a desire and a prayer of Christ Jesus that has been thus far unanswered. They contend that the unity of Faith and government, which is the sign of the true and only Church of Christ has almost never existed up to this time and does not exist today; it can be desired and perhaps in the future it can be obtained through general good will but meanwhile it must be considered a fiction. They say, moreover, that the Church by its very nature is divided into parts, that it consists of many churches or particular communities which are separated among themselves and, although they

[11]Matt. xxviii, 19.
[12]Matt. xxviii, 20.
[13]Matt. xvi, 18.
[14]John xvii, 21; x, 16.

have certain points of doctrine in common, differ in others; that each enjoys the same rights; that at most the Church was the one and only Church between the Apostolic era and the first Ecumenical Councils. Therefore, they add that the controversies and old differences of opinion, which up to our time have prevented the union of the Chrisitan name, should be completely put aside and with the remaining doctrines there ought to be formulated and proposed a common rule of faith in the profession of which all can know and feel themselves brothers; and that only when united by some sort of universal covenant can the multitude of churches or communities oppose fruitfully and effectively the progress of unbelief. This, Venerable Brethren, is the more general opinion.

There are, however, some among them who assume and grant that Protestantism, as they call it, has rejected inadvisedly certain articles of faith and certain external rites of worship which are fully acceptable and useful and which the Roman Church still preserves. But they add immediately that the Church has corrupted the early religion by adding to it and by proposing for belief certain doctrines that are not only foreign to but are opposed to the Gospel, among which they bring forward chiefly that of the primacy of jurisdiction assigned to Peter and his successors of the Roman See. Among them are also a few, though a very few, who grant to the Roman Pontiff a primacy of honor or a certain jurisdiction and power which, however, they derive not from Divine right but in a certain manner from the consent of the faithful; and others even add that they wish the Pope to preside over these multicolored conferences.

Seek Basis of Equality

If, however, it is easy to find many non-Catholics preaching often of brotherly love in Christ Jesus, you will, indeed, find none to whose mind it would occur to submit themselves and obey the Vicar of Christ either as teacher or as ruler of the Church. Meanwhile, they affirm that they wish very much to treat with the Roman Church, though upon the basis of equality of rights and as equals; if they could so treat, they do not doubt but

that an agreement might be entered into through which they would not be compelled to give up those opinions which are the cause why they have thus far wandered outside the one sheepfold of Christ.

On such conditions it is clear that the Apostolic See cannot in any way participate in their reunions and that Catholics cannot in any way adhere or grant aid to such efforts; if that would happen it would give authority to a false Christian religion completely foreign to the one Church of Christ. But could we suffer—which would be iniquitous—the truth and indeed the Divine revealed truth to be brought down to the level of bargains? For it is the safeguarding of revealed truth now that is being considered.

If Jesus Christ sent His Apostles throughout the whole world to imbue all nations with the evangelical faith and that they might not err in anything He desired that they be taught all truth by the Holy Ghost,[15] could this doctrine of the Apostles disappear or even be darkened in a Church of which God Himself is the ruler and guardian? And if Our Redeemer openly said that His Gospel cared not only for the Apostolic period but also for all future generations could it be that the content of the Faith would become in the passing of time so obscure and uncertain as to permit today the acceptance of opposed opinions? If that were true one must likewise say that the coming of the Holy Ghost upon the Apostles and the endless abiding in the Church of the Holy Ghost and even the preaching of Jesus Christ have for these many centuries lost all efficacy and usefulness. But to affirm that, would be blasphemy.

Moreover, when the Only Begotten Son of God commanded His legates to teach all nations, He then obliged all men to place faith in these things that had been announced to them by "witnesses preordained of God,"[16] and He attached to His command the sanction, "he that believeth and is baptized shall be saved: but he that believeth not shall be condemned."[17] Now this double commandment of Christ which must necessarily be observed, to teach and to believe so as to attain eternal salvation cannot even be understood if the Church does not propose the

[15]John xvi, 13. [16]Acts xi, 41. [17]Mark xvi, 16.

evangelical doctrine entire and clear, and if in the teaching of it it were not free from all danger of error.

God Revealed Truth

How far are they from the truth who indeed think that a deposit of truth exists on earth but who think too that one must search for it with so much tiring labor and lengthy studies and disputes that hardly is the life of a man long enough to find it and enjoy it; as if the most kind God has spoken through the prophets and His Only Begotten Son that a few only and these already bowed down in years should learn the truth that He has revealed and not that man might have a teaching of faith and morals through which he would be ruled throughout the whole course of his life.

It might appear that the Pan-Christians, engaged in trying to confederate the churches, are pursuing the noble idea of promoting charity among all Christians. Yet how can charity come from harm done the Faith? All remember how John, the very Apostle of charity, who in his gospel seems to have revealed the secrets of the Most Sacred Heart of Jesus and who inculcated always in the minds of his disciples the new commandment, "Love ye one another," had wholly forbidden them to have relations with those who did not profess entire and uncorrupted the doctrine of Christ: "If any men cometh to you and bring not this doctrine, receive him not into your house nor say to him, God speed you."[18] Since charity is founded in whole and sincere faith, the disciples of Christ must be united by the bond of unity in faith and by it as the chief bond. How could a Christian society be considered whose members in matters of Faith could each retain his own way of thinking and judging, although it was contrary to the beliefs of others? Through what agreement could men of opposed opinions become one and the same society of the Faithful?

How, for example, can they who affirm that sacred tradition is a true source of Divine Revelation, and they who deny it become members of one church? They who hold that an ecclesiastical authority formed of bishops, priests and ministers is Divinely constituted, and they who

[18]II John x.

assert that little by little it has been introduced through conditions of time and events? They who adore Christ really present in the Most Holy Eucharist by that wonderful change of bread and wine called Transubstantiation and they who say that the Body of Christ is present there only through the sign and the virtue of the sacrament; they who hold that in the Eucharist there is a sacrifice and a sacrament, and they who say that it is only a remembrance or commemoration of the suffering of Our Lord? They who believe it good and useful to pray to the saints reigning with Christ and above all to Mary the Virgin Mother of God and to venerate their images, and they who pretend that such a form of worship is wrong because it draws from the honor due Jesus Christ, "the one mediator of God and men."[19]

Differences Prevent Unity

In such great differences of opinions we do not know how a road may be paved to the unity of the Church save alone through one teaching authority, one sole law of belief and one sole faith among Christians. Moreover, we know how easy is the path to neglect of religion, to indifferentism and also to modernism which holds the very same error, to wit: dogmatic truth is not absolute but relative, it is proportionate to the different needs of times and places and to the various tendencies of the mind since it is not based upon an unchanging revelation but is to be accommodated to the life of men.

In matters of Faith it is, moreover, not permissible to make a distinction between fundamental and so-called non-fundamental articles of Faith, as if the first ought to be held by all and the second are free for the Faithful to accept or not. The supernatural virtue of Faith has as its formal cause the authority of God the Revealer, who does not make such a division. Therefore, as many as are of Christ give, for example, to the dogma of the Immaculate Conception the same faith they give to the mystery of the august Trinity and they believe in the infallible teaching power of the Pope, in the sense, be it understood, determined by the Vatican Ecumenical Council. Not because

[19]Cf. I Tim. ii, 5.

the Church has defined and sanctioned truths by solemn decree of the Church at different times, and even in times near to us are they, therefore, of unequal certainty and to be given unequal faith; for has not God revealed them all?

The teaching authority of the Church which by Divine providence was established in the world in order that revealed truths might always be preserved untouched, and quickly and with certainty come to the minds of men, is daily exercised by the Roman Pontiff and the bishops in communion with him. Still it has the duty to proceed opportunely in defining points of Faith with solemn rights and decrees, when it becomes the duty to declare them in order to resist more effectively the errors and assaults of heretics or to impress upon the minds of the Faithful clearer and more profound expositions of points of sacred doctrine. However, in this extraordinary use of the teaching authority nothing is invented nor is anything new added to the sum of truths that are, at least implicitly, contained in the deposit of Divine Revelation that was entrusted by God to the Church, but instead points of Faith are defined that could still seem obscure to some, or truths are established as matters of Faith that for the first time were entering controversy.

Catholics Forbidden Participation

Therefore, Venerable Brethren, it is clear why the Apostolic See has never permitted its children to take part in these congresses of non-Catholics; because the unity of Christians cannot be otherwise obtained than by securing the return of the separated to the one true Church of Christ from which they once unhappily withdrew, to the one true Church of Christ, standing forth before all and which by the will of its Founder will remain forever the same as when He Himself established it for the salvation of all mankind. The mystical Spouse of Christ has remained unspotted in the course of the centuries nor can it ever be contaminated. St. Cyprian says: "The Spouse of Christ cannot commit adultery; she is incorrupt and modest, she knows one house, she guards with chastity and modesty the sanctity of one room."[20] The holy martyr marveled, and with reason, how any one could think

[20]De Cath. Ecclesiae unitate, 6.

that "the unity which proceeds from the stability of God and is bound together by the sacraments of heaven could be torn asunder in the Church or divorced by discordant wills."[21] For since the mystical Body of Christ, that is to say, the Church is, like the physical body a unity,[22] a compact thing, closely joined together,[23] it would be false and foolish to say that Christ's mystical Body could be composed of disjointed and separated members. Whoever, therefore, is not united with it is not a member of it nor does he communicate with its head who is Christ.[24]

In the one Church of Christ no one is found there and no one perseveres in it unless he recognizes and accepts obediently the supreme authority of St. Peter and his legitimate successors. Did not the very ancestors of those who were confused by the errors of Photius and the Protestants obey the Roman bishop as the high shepherd of souls? Children did, alas, abandon their father's house but the house did not therefore fall in ruins, supported as it was by the unceasing help of God. Let them return to the common father of all; he has forgotten the unjust wrongs inflicted against the Holy See and will receive them most lovingly. If, as they repeat, they desire to be united with Us and with Ours, why do they not hasten to return to the Church "the mother and mistress of all the followers of Christ"?[25] Let them listen to Lactantius crying out: "It is only the Catholic Church that retains the true worship. It is the fountain of truth, it is the household of the Faith, it is the temple of God, so that if any one does not enter it or if any one departs from it, he is a stranger to the hope of life and salvation. No one should be deceived by continuous disputes. Life and salvation are in the balance; if they are not cared for carefully and diligently they will be lost and destroyed."[26]

Let these separated children return to the Apostolic See established in this city which the Princes of the Apostles, Peter and Paul, consecrated with their blood, to this See, "the root and matrix of the Catholic Church,"[27] not, indeed, with the idea or hope that "the Church of the liv-

[21]Ibid. [22]I Cor. xii, 12. [23]Eph. iv, 16.
[24]Cf. Eph. v, 30; i, 22. [25]Conc. Lateran, IV, c.5.
[26]Divin. Instit. 4, 30, 11-12.
[27]S. Cypr. Ep. 48 ad Cornelium, 3.

ing God, the pillar and ground of truth"[28] will abandon the integrity of the Faith and bear their errors, but to subject themselves to its teaching authority and rule. Would that what has not been granted to Our predecessors would be granted to Us, to embrace with the heart of a father the children over whom We mourn in their separation from Us by evil discord. May God Our Saviour, "who will have all men to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth,"[29] hearken to our ardent prayer and vouchsafe to call back all the wanderers to the unity of the Church! In behalf of which lofty intention We invoke, and We ask that you invoke, the intercession of the Blessed Virgin Mary, Mother of Divine Grace, Conqueror of all heresies and Help of Christians, that soon there may dawn that longed-for day when all men will hear the voice of her Divine Son "keeping the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace."[30] You know well, Venerable Brethren, how much We want their return; and We desire too, that all Our children know it and not only they of the Catholic world but all who are separated from Us. If they who are separated from Us will ask in humble prayer the grace of God, there is no doubt but that they will recognize the one true Church of Jesus Christ and enter it united at last with Us in perfect charity. In expectation of it and as a sign of the favor of God and a witness of Our Fatherly benevolence to you, Venerable Brethren, and to your clergy and people We impart the Apostolic Blessing.

Given at St. Peter's the sixth of January, the Feast of the Epiphany of Our Lord Jesus Christ, in the year nineteen twenty-eight, the sixth of Our Pontificate.

PIUS XI, Pope.

[28] I Tim. iii, 15. [29] I Tim. ii, 4. [30] Eph. iv, 3.

The Pope's Encyclical

FRANCIS X. TALBOT, S.J.

Sermon preached at St. Ignatius Church, Manhattan, New York City, on the occasion of the publication of the Encyclical.

ON the feast of the Epiphany, the Holy Father, Pius XI, issued an encyclical letter to the Bishops and to all the faithful of the Catholic Church throughout the world on the subject of Church unity. This encyclical was most appropriate to the feast of the Epiphany, and most significant to the religious situation of these days. For on this feast is commemorated the visit of the Magi from the East to the crib of Christ, to bring to Him the tribute and the adoration of the Gentile world. On that day, Christ gave His message of salvation to the first converts not of His fold, and on this last commemoration of that day, the spokesman of Christ and His representative on earth delivered a message which has a deep meaning for those who are not of the Catholic fold. This encyclical message has an outstanding significance for the modern relgious world and especially for our own country and for Great Britain. It touches upon those issues which are at present uppermost in the minds of serious-thinking religious men and women, upon those aspirations for a greater unity between all the followers of Christ that have been growing stronger each successive year. This encyclical has been sent broadcast through the world first and foremost to Catholics, to re-state for them the age-long teaching of the Catholic Church on the unity of that Church, both in itself and in its relation to other religious bodies, and to guide Catholics in their attitudes towards the current tendencies of a universal Church rapprochement.

PROTESTANT EFFORTS

This past decade since 1918 and the close of the war has been characterized thus far by a determined effort to bring about the abolition of barriers between nations, and

races, and religions. These efforts have been in many departments and of various kinds. There is the League of Nations and the World Court for the settlement of disputes and the promotion of peace and amity between nation and nation. There is the Pan-American Conference which assembled recently at Havana for the peaceable discussion of problems that affect the nations who are neighbors on these two Western Continents. And as the nations are seeking to find a common platform of aspirations and of action, so, too, the religious denominations have been trying to devise plans by which all those who profess belief in Christ would be united and would work for God's glory in peace and fraternity.

There has been almost a complete reversal in the attitude of the modern non-Catholic denominations from that of the sixteenth century reformers. At the time of the so-called Reformation, Christian unity was severed and reprobated. A universal Church, uniting all men and all nations under one single head and with one, single doctrine, was repudiated for national churches and for contradictory beliefs. During the four centuries since that lamentable break in Christian unity, the Mother Church under the headship of the Pope, Christ's vicar on earth, has prayed for the return of the erring children who rejected her; and during those four centuries, the national churches of Luther and Calvin and Knox and Henry and Elizabeth and Cramner have continued their own vagrant way, glorying in their independence and content in their isolation. But now a new spirit has entered into them. They aspire to unity. They wish ardently to discover some common basis of organization and of belief. The corporate reunion of the Anglican communion with Rome has for long years occupied the minds of Church leaders in England and the United States. It was with this corporate reunion in mind that the Malines Conferences were conducted from 1921 to 1925 between Lord Halifax and his Anglican associates, and Cardinal Mercier. A more expansive idea was that expressed by Bishop Manning of New York when at the thirteenth-centenary celebration of York Minster he declared that Anglicanism sought to be a bridge between Catholicism and Protestantism since the Anglican Church was both Catholic and Protestant. The efforts of our American Protestant Churches to ef-

fect some sort of union between themselves have been many and sincere. But the most ambitious attempt for Church unity was that of the Lausanne Conference of last summer when representatives from the leading Protestant denominations of the world, yes, and from the Eastern Orthodox Church, met to discuss the possibilities for a world-union of the various religious bodies that profess to follow Christ.

Catholic Attitude

What of the Catholic Church in regard to these efforts to promote Christian unity? The Catholic Church sent no representatives, either official or unofficial, to the world conference of religion at Lausanne. The Pope has now issued an encyclical in which he declares emphatically that the Catholic Church can have and will have no part in any such conferences or congresses such as that at Lausanne. Did that mean that the Catholic Church was opposed to these sincere strivings for religious harmony? Is this encyclical a rebuff to the Protestant Churches of the world who have been promoting these conferences?

The Reaction

The encyclical has been interpreted in this sense by our separated brothers. I venture to say that denunciations of the Pope and invectives of the Catholic Church are ringing from most of the Protestant pulpits this Sunday morning. The press comments of Protestant leaders already made show that they felt themselves offended, nay insulted, nay outraged, by the Pope's latest message to his own spiritual children. This man considers that the encyclical was designed to discourage hopes for a unified world-church. That man considers it reactionary and illiberal in the worst degree. Another finds it wholly opposed to the American spirit of democracy and to the modern tendency towards cooperation in religion. While still another is grieved because the encyclical delivers a body-blow to Christian endeavors for peace and strengthens and fortifies the arguments of the radical extremists against all religion. They see other evil effects that must result from this encyclical in social and political spheres, from the defeat of the plans for the temporal sovereignty

of the Pope to that of Governor Smith for President, from the strengthening of anti-Roman sentiment against the Prayer Book in England to the formation of a self-defense union of the Protestants in the United States.

In addition to this Protestant criticism that the Pope's encyclical has aroused, I am sad to say that there may be some Catholics who may be somewhat regretful because of this message. Just as there were Catholics a half century ago who considered the definition of the dogma of the Immaculate Conception and the declaration on Papal infallibility blundering and inopportune, just as there were those a decade and a half ago who felt that the condemnation of Modernism by Pius X, was intolerant and harsh, so, too, there may be those today who look upon this encyclical as a matter of regret. But I say to all, Catholic as well as non-Catholic, that there is nothing to apologize for in this encyclical, nothing to excuse or explain away, nothing to regret either as to its contents or as to its timeliness. The Holy Father, Pius XI, was obliged to speak on this subject of Church unity, and he was obliged to speak in precisely the terms of this encyclical. As Father of Christ's Church, he had a duty to warn his children against that faltering and compromising tendency that is so subtle a danger to Catholic ideals in our modern world, and a further duty to lay aside all question of expediency and to tell those not his children in honest, in upright, in fearless fashion what are the Catholic principles on the union of Christendom.

Truth hurts. Truth is a sharp sword that cuts clean and deep. Truth is fatal to vain illusions and to fanciful aspirations. Truth is hostile to vague thinking and to illogical reasoning. And that is the reason why the present encyclical of Pius XI has proved distasteful to those visionaries who have been working so earnestly, and yet so foolishly, on an impossible project for uniting the churches of Christendom.

False and True Theories

As the Holy Father clearly points out, there is a false and a true theory of Christian reunion, and there is a false and a true approach to the settlement of religious differences. The false view is founded on such principles

as these: all forms of religion are good and meritorious; it makes no difference to what religious allegiance a man binds himself provided he honors and adores God; one religion is as good as another; dogmatic beliefs are not necessary for a man to be a true follower of Christ; dogmatic truth is not immutable, is not absolute, but is relative and comparative, is subject to change by reason of time, or circumstances, or newer discoveries and tendencies; dogmas may be regarded as fundamental or non-fundamental, and the like. From these principles, the promoters of the false view on Christian unity proceed to draw up their programs. They protest that charity and love transcend intellectual definitions in the religion of Christ. They send out invitations to men of all Christian beliefs and persuasions, even to those who publicly and persistently deny the Divinity of Christ, to men of all sects, to Modernist as to Fundamentalist, so that they may all gather to discuss anew the fundamentals of the Christian religion and so that they may eventually arrive at or devise some doctrine or doctrines that are acceptable to all. They even go so far that they declare that they are willing, nay anxious, to have the Catholic Church take part in such general discussions of religion, as one church among many churches. They state that they will grant equal rights to the Catholic Church as to other denominations. They offer the hand of friendship and of brotherhood to us of the Catholic Church and invite us to take part in their deliberations upon this noble and laudable quest of the union of Christian churches.

An Uncompromising "No"

Our answer to them, to their theories and to their approach, is given in this encyclical. It is "no." It is a firm and an uncompromising "no." It is an absolute refusal to subscribe to their program. Our answer to them, in plain language, is that their efforts are based on false principles, no matter what their good faith and their sincerity may be. Our complete answer to them is the presentation to them of the Catholic solution for world union of Christendom. This answer is clearly expressed in the Pope's encyclical. But it is not something that the Pope has newly discovered; it is age-old doctrine of the

Catholic Church merely once more re-stated, it is the traditional belief applied to contemporary events and circumstances, it is what you and I believed as much before the Papal encyclical as after it. Those who profess to be offended by it, be they Catholic or be they non-Catholic, prove that they were ignorant of the fundamental Catholic doctrines that it expresses.

Christ came to our earth to offer redemption to mankind. Christ founded a Church that was a visible society. He intended that this Church which He founded should last till the end of time and He promised to watch over and to preserve this Church through all the ages of the world. Christ founded one Church, and only one. He gave to that one Church, one constitution and that most definite and exclusive. He appointed one single head on earth to that Church, one magistracy that would be carried down through all the generations and the centuries. He established one, single deposit of faith, one body of beliefs, one single and immutable doctrine. The custodian of this one doctrine of Christ is the one Church that derives directly from Him, the Catholic Church in obedience to the Pope. There are not two churches or two hundred churches of Christ. There is but one Church of Christ. There are not many interpretations of Christ's teachings; there is only one legitimate interpretation, and that is the interpretation of the Catholic Church. There are not many varieties of religious truth; truth is single, and unchangeable.

In the light of this, then, how foolish it is for men to be so deceived as to think that at this late date they can get together in conferences and congresses to discuss the essential doctrines of Christ, that they may gather under no authoritative head or supreme representative of Christ to attain a unity of churches. There can be no new and modern amalgamation of many churches to form the single Church of Christ, there can be no pooling of differences and no programs of compromises that will result in giving us a pure and unadulterated version of the teachings of Christ. There can be no twentieth-century discovery of another basis of agreement in religion.

The Catholic Church, aware of its high prerogatives, convinced of its Divine origin, firm in its steadfast profession of Christ's Faith, pure and unchanged, can enter

into no discussion such as that of the Lausanne Conference. The Catholic Church alone has religious truth, it alone has all religious truth, and it alone has none but religious truth. It cannot compromise on one single doctrine expressed in that religious truth, though the world fall thereby. It cannot change any one single doctrine revealed by God and handed down by tradition. It cannot retract its belief of the past, it cannot modify that belief to fit the modern world. It cannot barter with other religious beliefs nor can it pool its differences. Is this intolerance? If it is, let the Catholic Church be intolerant. And for myself, I may say that if the Catholic Church should relinquish one solitary dogma of her deposit, one dogma that she ever taught as revealed by Christ and as defined by her, if the Catholic Church, I repeat, ever modified or retracted such a dogma, then I for one would cease to pay allegiance to that Church or to accept its claims, for if it was mistaken in one instance I would have no guarantee that it was not mistaken in a hundred other instances.

Reunion Only Through Submission

There is, then, only one common ground for the discussion of the reunion of Protestantism, in all its forms, and of the Catholic Church. That common ground is the doctrine of Christ as taught by the Catholic Church, and by the Catholic Church alone. If there is to be reunion—and no one desires it more than I—the reunion must be only—and this may sound harsh—through submission to the Catholic Church. And that is what the Pope has proclaimed in his encyclical.

Oh! but the Catholic Church desires this true reunion of all Christ's followers, it prays its founder and its head, Christ, to hurry the day when such a reunion takes effect. It begs those children, whose fathers have left the true Communion, to return once more. Its doors are open to them to enter freely under the inspiration of the Holy Ghost. May they lift up their eyes, as the Magi did, and follow the star, and follow till they come to the true Church, may they lift up their eyes and gaze with love upon the Church, the pure and the steadfast mystical Bride of Christ.

Reunion

Rt. Rev. Msgr. John L. Belford

Extract from a sermon preached at the Church of the Nativity, Brooklyn, N. Y.

THE Pope merely proclaimed that the way to reunion is for the deserters to return. If the Church was ever right, it is everlastingly right. If it was right in the First Century, it is right in this century. If reunion means the rejection of error, she has no error to reject. But the deserters are in error. They have left their Father's house. They have listened to men. They have refused to hear the voice of the Spirit.

It is not without reason that they are anxious, disturbed, unhappy. The way to peace is through truth. This truth men cannot find. They tried to find it. It took ages of effort and failure to convince them that mere reason could not make, recognize or accept truth. That is why God sent prophets. Then He sent His Son. Now He sends the Church. The same voice spoke in prophecy which afterward spoke in Christ and which now speaks in and through the Church. . . .

The Church is deeply interested in the reunion of Christendom. She knows the prayer of Christ, "that they may be one," but cannot dilute her doctrine nor modify her message. The prodigal must come home. With open arms she awaits him. She will not chide or chastise. She will rejoice over him more even than she rejoices over those who have never left her. But she longs for the day when she can proclaim, "This is my son! He was lost and he is found! He was dead and he is alive!" No sweeter music ever stirred the air since the angels sang, "Glory to God on high; on earth, peace to men of good will!" . . .

This letter of the Pope will promote discussion. It will bring light. It will do good. The truth is mighty. It will prevail. God will reign. The Church will fulfill her mission. In God's own time, we shall all be one flock with one shepherd.